INCLUSIVE DESIGN / COMPLIANCE

ACCESSIBILITY IS NOT OPTIONAL

WCAG 2.1 AA is a legal requirement in the EU, UK, US, and most major markets. Accessible systems are better engineered: cleaner semantic structure, more robust, serving a broader user base. Retrofitting accessibility is 5–10× more expensive than building it in.

KEY BENEFITS

- ✓ Avoids legal liability — accessibility lawsuits and regulatory fines are rising sharply
- ✓ Expands addressable market — 1 in 5 people have a disability affecting digital use
- ✓ Improves SEO — accessible semantic markup is rewarded by search engines
- ✓ Better code quality overall — accessibility constraints drive cleaner component design

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

Domino's Pizza lost a landmark US Supreme Court case in 2019 establishing digital ADA compliance. The EU's European Accessibility Act, enforced from 2025, applies across all EU digital products.

PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

Every design system component is built with axe-core tests and keyboard navigation as acceptance criteria. A new modal is flagged in CI for missing focus trapping. Fixed before the PR merges — not in a compliance audit six months later.

REFLECTION QUESTION

When did you last test your product with a screen reader? Is accessibility part of your definition of done?